

Lecture 04 (2026-07-04)

Quick Summary

- Introduction to Group Behavior (Lecture 9).
- Distinction between Groups and Teams (to be covered in the next session).
- Definition and classification of Groups (Formal vs. Informal).
- The Punctuated Equilibrium Model of group development.
- Stages of group development (Conflict resolution, Norming, Performing).
- Key properties of groups: roles, norms, status, size, cohesiveness, and diversity.
- The role of social pressure in group behavior (Solomon Ash experiments).
- Distinction between Informational and Normative Conformity.
- The "Weightage of Situation" rule for determining when to conform or not.
- Comparative analysis of decision-making techniques (Interacting, Brainstorming, Nominal).
- The "Calamities of Consensus" and the trade-offs between consensus and optimal results.
- Management strategies for role clarity, cohesion, and team composition.
- Upcoming items: Common individual assignment (15 marks) involving experiential learning; Case Study "WIPL" (to be discussed in Session 10); and Quiz 2 (5% weight).

Key Definitions

- **Group:** Two or more individuals, interacting and interdependent, come together to achieve a particular objective.
- **Formal Groups:** Defined as part of the organizational structure; defined by the workplace/organization (e.g., an airline flight crew).
- **Informal Groups:** Not defined by organizational structure; includes social clubs, interest groups, and lunch/tea groups.
- **Punctuated Equilibrium Model:** A model of group development where progress is not linear but marked by long periods of inertia interrupted by "revolutionary changes" (spikes in activity) typically triggered by a deadline.
- **Norming:** The stage where group members agree upon their roles, how they will perform them, and the methods used to achieve the group's objectives.
- **Performing:** The final stage of group development where members work collaboratively to achieve the group's objectives.
- **Role:** The expected behavior attributed to someone occupying a position in a social unit.
- **Role Perception:** An individual's own perception of how they are expected to act in a given situation/role.
- **Role Expectations:** The expectations of others regarding how an individual should act in a given situation; often considered a "psychological contract."
- **Role Conflict:** A situation in which an individual is confronted by differing role expectations (e.g., their own perception of their role vs. the expectations of others).
- **Norms:** Acceptable standards of behavior within a group that are shared by the group members.
- **Conformity:** The adjustment of one's behavior to align with the norms of the group.
- **Status:** A socially defined position or rank given to groups or group members by others.
Status Sources:
 - The power a person wields over others.
 - A person's ability to contribute to a group's goals.

- An individual's personal characteristics (e.g., personality, charisma).
- **Informational Conformity:** Conforming because the individual is convinced/convinced by what the group says that they are correct (a belief-based shift).
- **Normative Conformity:** Conforming because the individual is apprehensive that the group will disapprove if they are "deviant" or an "outlier" (a fear-based, behavior-based shift).
- **Pygmalion Effect:** The phenomenon where people tend to act according to the expectations set for them (e.g., low expectations for politicians lead to lower "surprising" output; high expectations for soldiers lead to high discipline/output).
- **Cohesiveness:** How well bonded the individuals are; a shared bond driving group members to work together and stay together.
- **Social Loafing:** The tendency for individuals to expend less effort when working collectively than alone.
- **Participative Management:** A management style where individual opinions are actively sought, which increases trust, job satisfaction, and organizational commitment.
- **[Screen Content: Groups - Types]**
- **Definition:** "Two or more individuals, interacting and interdependent, who have come together to achieve particular objectives."
- **Formal Groups:** Defined by org. structure (Example: Airline flight crew).
- **Informal Groups:** Includes Social clubs, Interest groups, and lunch and tea groups.
- **[Screen Content: Group Types Classification]**
- **Definition:** "Two or more individuals, interacting, and interdependent, who have come together to achieve particular objectives."
- **Formal Groups:** Defined by org. structure (Example: Airline flight crew).
- **Informal Groups:** Includes Social clubs, Interest groups, and just lunch and tea groups.
- **[Screen Content: Group Properties - Roles]**
- **Role**
- **Role Perception**
- **Role Expectations - Psychological Contract**
- **Role Conflict**
- **[Screen Content: Stanford Prison Experiment YouTube Video]**
- **Title:** The Stanford Prison Experiment Explained
- **Context:** Study on the psychology of authority, conformity, and human behavior under confinement.
- **[Screen Content: Prison Environment Analysis]**
- **Context:** Transporting [sic] prisoners to jail.
- **Key Concepts:** DEPERSONALIZE, GIVEN AUTHORITY OVER PRISONERS.
- **[Screen Content: Narrative slide on escalating conditions]**
- **Timeline:** Second day.
- **Headings:** ESCALATING CONDITIONS, Extreme measures.
- **Actions:** Prisoners rebelled.
- **[Screen Content: Stanford Prison Experiment and Limbic System Overview]**
- **Title:** STANFORD PRISON EXPERIMENT (Dark side of human behavior).
- **Note:** Includes Limbic System/Memory (Amygdala & Hippocampus).
- **[Screen Content: Group Properties - Roles]**
- **Role**
- **Role Perception**
- **Role Expectations - Psychological Contract**
- **Role Conflict**
- **[Screen_00-38-36.png] Group Properties - Norms**
- **Norms:** acceptable standards of behavior within a group that are shared by the group's members.
- **Conformity:** the adjustment of one's behavior to align with the norms of group.

- **[Screen_00-40-37.png] Group Properties - Status**
- **Status:** a socially defined position or rank given to groups or group members by others.
- **Status characteristics theory:** differences in status characteristics create status hierarchies within groups.
- **Status Sources:**
 - The power a person wields over others
 - A person's ability to contribute to a group's goals
 - An individual's personal characteristics
- **[Screen_01-00-10.png] Group Properties - Size**
- **Size:** Group size affects the group's overall behavior.
- **Social loafing:** the tendency for individuals to expend less effort when working collectively than alone.
- **Small groups (3-7 members):** Better for decision making and participation.
- **Large groups (10+ members):** Better for generating diverse ideas but may suffer from social loafing.
- **[Screen_01-03-37.png] Group Properties - Roles**
- **Role:** Function occupied by someone occupying a given position in a group.
- **Role Perception:** Individual's view of how they should act in a given situation.
- **Role Expectations - Psychological Contract:** How others believe an individual should act in a given situation.
- **Role Conflict:** Individual is confronted by divergent role expectations.
- **Note:** Refers to the Zimbardo Prison Experiment.
- **[shot_01-07-42.png] Group Properties - Size**
- **Core Principle:** Group size affects the group's overall behavior.
- **Social Loafing:** Defined as the tendency for individuals to expend less effort when working collectively than alone.
- **Small groups (3-7 members):** Better for decision making and participation.
- **Large groups (10+ members):** Better for generating diverse ideas but may suffer from social loafing.
- **[shot_01-13-14.png] Group Properties - Cohesiveness Matrix**
- **Y-axis:** Performance Norms (High, Low)
- **X-axis:** Cohesiveness (High, Low)
- **High Performance Norms + High Cohesiveness:** High productivity
- **High Performance Norms + Low Cohesiveness:** Moderate productivity
- **Low Performance Norms + High Cohesiveness:** Low productivity
- **Low Performance Norms + Low Cohesiveness:** Moderate to low productivity
- **[shot_01-16-30.png] Group Decision Making Strengths and Weaknesses**
- **Strengths**
 - More complete information and knowledge
 - accuracy
 - Diversity of views - creativity
 - Acceptance of a solution
- **Weaknesses**
 - Time consuming
 - Conformity pressures
 - Dominated by one or few members
 - Diluted responsibility/accountability
- **[shot_01-26-54.png] Group Decision Making Techniques (Comparative Metrics)**
- **Selection Criteria Table:** | Effectiveness Criteria | Interacting | Brainstorming | Nominal | | :--- | :--- | :--- | :--- | | Number and quality of ideas | Low | Moderate | High | | Social Pressure | High | Lower | Lower

| | Cost | Equal | Equal | Equal | | Speed | Moderate | Moderate | Moderate | | Task Orientation | Low (High potential for noise/chaos) | High (More pointed/focused) | High (More pointed/focused) | | Potential for Conflict | Highest | Lower | Moderate | | Commitment to Solution | Higher | Moderate | Moderate |

- **Note:** Number and quality of ideas are higher in **Nominal** because the prompt to write allows more space for thought and reduces hesitation/pressure of speaking out. **Brainstorming** is more restricted because members must speak out, though the "No Criticism" rule helps. **Interacting** is the most restricted as introverts may not have the opportunity to speak.

Worked Examples

Stanford Prison Experiment (1971):

- **Context:** Conducted at Stanford University by Philip Zimbardo.
- **Setup:** 24 male students assigned as guards or prisoners in a mock prison.
- **Observation:** Guards quickly became abusive/sadistic; prisoners became distressed/submissive.

Key Findings:

- **Deindividuation:** Individuals lost their sense of identity/moral responsibility when forced into a group role.
- **Learned Helplessness:** Prisoners accepted oppression when escape seemed impossible.
- **Application:** Used to illustrate how individuals can become overly "attached" to assigned roles, leading to the loss of personal ethics or empathy.

Solomon Ash Line Length Experiment:

Initial Study (Single Subject): One subject (the 5th person) was asked to judge the length of a line. Others were confederates who gave deliberately wrong answers.

- **Finding:** The subject conformed to the group's wrong answer in 37% of "critical trials."
- **Reasoning:** This showed that subjects would deny their own senses to yield to group influence.

Variation 1 (Partner Presence): The subject was given a partner who also gave the correct response.

- **Finding:** Conforming dropped significantly to only 5%.
- **Reasoning:** This demonstrates that the power of the group comes from the **unanimity of its opposition**. When that unanimity is "punctured" by a single other person who is correct, the pressure to conform is greatly reduced.

Variation 2 (Private Response): The subject was told they would have to write their answer rather than say it out loud.

- **Finding:** Conformity dropped by two-thirds.
- **Reasoning:** This isolates **Normative Conformity**. Because the subject did not have to fear the immediate social "judgment" or criticism of being an outlier, the need to conform to the group's behavior was removed.

Group Decision-Making Techniques:

Interacting Groups:

- **Method:** Members meet face-to-face and discuss the issue openly.
- **Reasoning:** This is a standard meeting format; however, it often leads to members "censoring" themselves and feeling pressured toward conformity (similar to the findings in the Ash study).

Brainstorming:

Process:

1. A leader presents the problem/question on screen or verbally.
 2. Members are given a set time (e.g., 30-45 minutes) to "free-wheel" as many alternatives as possible.
 3. **Strict Rule:** No criticism is allowed during the brainstorming phase.
- **Reasoning:** This allows for a high volume of diverse ideas without the fear of immediate judgment.

Nominal Group Technique:

Process:

1. Each member writes down their ideas privately.
 2. A period of silence follows while everyone writes.
 3. Each member presents their idea to the group.
 4. The group discusses each idea to gain clarity/detail.
 5. The ideas are rank-ordered (e.g., "This is number one").
 6. The leader combines/compiles the top-ranked ideas to reach a final decision.
- **Reasoning:** This reduces the pressure of conformity by allowing individuals to present their ideas before the group can influence them through discussion.

Case Study: The Calamities of Consensus:

- **Context:** Exploration of why consensus is not always the optimal route for decision-making.
- **Pros of Consensus:** High camaraderie, trust, and commitment; because everyone agrees, they are more invested in the outcome.

Cons of Consensus (The "Calamities"):

- **Sub-optimal outcomes:** Pressure to reach consensus can lead to "groupthink" or an "average" solution that everyone can tolerate but no one loves.
- **Time Constraints:** In emergencies (e.g., the 2012 **Fiscal Cliff**), there is no time for a democratic consensus.
- **Inaccurate Majority:** A consensus can be based on a popular but ultimately incorrect assumption (e.g., the initial belief that **Obamacare** would be ruled unconstitutional).
- **Alternative Model:** Individual decision-making with a "gathering" phase. A leader takes input from everyone but makes the final, solo call. This ensures the decision is made while still providing the team with a voice.

Formulas & Rules

- **Rule: Group Size Utility:** Use larger groups for fact-finding (seeking diverse input) and smaller groups for action-taking (requiring quick execution/decisions).
- **Rule: The Rule of "No Criticism":** In brainstorming, the "No Criticism" rule is essential to ensure the "free-wheeling" of ideas and to bypass conformity pressures.

Tricky Logic & Traps

- **Punctuated Equilibrium Model Logic:** Students often assume group development is a steady, linear climb. The model highlights that groups often experience "inertia" (no progress) during the first few weeks. The "trigger" (e.g., a deadline) is what causes the jump in performance.
- **The Transition Phase:** In the Punctuated Equilibrium model, the first jump occurs when the team realizes the deadline is approaching and starts formulating a plan (identifying roles, etc.).
- **Second Inertia/Final Push:** There is a second period of inertia following the first transition, followed by a final spike in performance as the deadline becomes imminent.
- **Groups vs. Teams:** The instructor explicitly noted that "Groups" and "Teams" are different concepts; ensure you do not conflate the two, as they are analyzed separately in the following session.
- **Role Perception vs. Role Expectation:** A common point of confusion is that **Role** is the assigned position, while **Role Perception** is your own internal view of how to act, and **Role Expectation** is the "psychological contract" of what others believe you should do.
- **Role Conflict Trigger:** Conflict does not arise just from having a role, but specifically when there is a gap between an individual's **Role Perception** and the **Role Expectations** of others.
- **Conformity:** This is not just "following the rules," but the active adjustment of behavior to align with the norms of group.

- **Deindividuation:** As shown in the Zimbardo experiment, individuals can lose their sense of personal identity when they identify too strongly with a group role, leading to a breakdown of individual moral judgment.
- **The "Unanimity" Factor:** In the Ash experiments, the primary power of a group comes from the **unanimity of its opposition**. If the unanimity is "punctuated" (e.g., by a single partner who disagrees), the pressure on the individual to conform is significantly reduced.
- **Informational vs. Normative Conformity:** It is critical to distinguish between:
 - **Informational:** Conforming because the group's information is convincing.
 - **Normative:** Conforming to avoid being an "outlier" or facing potential criticism.
- **Conformity and Significance (The "Weightage" Rule):** Determining whether one should conform or have the "courage to not conform" depends on the **weightage of the situation**.
 - **Low-weight/Low-stakes:** (e.g., choosing a venue for a team outing) Conforming is often practical for harmony.
 - **High-weight/High-stakes:** If the issue involves personal safety, physical/mental health, fundamental personal beliefs, or significant organizational impact, one should have the courage to not conform.
- **Management of Outliers/Conflict:** Managers should use **one-on-one meetings** to understand if an individual is an "outlier" or if there is a genuine conflict. This helps the manager if the individual is struggling with "bandwidth" or "courage" to speak up in a group setting.
- **Status Differentiation:** Status is not just a title; it is tied to the perceived **power** of the role (e.g., a Production/Plant Manager often holds higher status than a Cost Center Manager like Finance/Tax because they are closer to the "product" side).
- **Role Rotation Logic:** Rotating roles is useful for diversity/trying new things, but **only** if the individual is equipped with the necessary skills. Rotating for the sake of variety without proper competency can be counterproductive.
- **Decision-Making Trade-offs:** Choosing between a group or individual decision is a "double-edged sword." Group decisions provide more info and diverse views but suffer from **diluted accountability** and **conformity pressures**. Use the specific context of the question to determine if the benefit of shared perspectives outweighs the cost of group processing time and lack of individual accountability.
- **Brainstorming vs. Norms:** In a proper Brainstorming session, the "No Criticism" rule is essential to ensure the "free-wheeling" of ideas.
- **The Consensus Trap:** Consensus is often seen as "good" because it builds trust and commitment. However, it can be **detrimental** in high-stakes or time-sensitive situations where it leads to "less-than-optimal" solutions, "groupthink," or compromises on core principles (e.g., the Fiscal Cliff or Healthcare debates).
- **Compromise vs. Optimal:** A decision reached via consensus is not guaranteed to be the optimal one; it is simply the one that is "liked" by the most people to avoid conflict.
- **Cohesion and Productivity:** Non-cohesive groups can lower productivity. If a member is not "gelling" with the group and is not interested in the objective, the manager may choose to remove them rather than trying to "paste" them into the group.
- **Management - Fact-finding vs. Action-taking:** Differentiation in group size is key; use larger groups for gathering data (fact-finding) and smaller groups for executing specific tasks (action-taking).
- **Revaluation Logic:** When applying for a revaluation, do **not** use generic claims (e.g., "can you please award more marks"). Requests must be **pointed** and **specific** to be successfully considered by the evaluator.

Exam Pointers

- **Case-Based Approach:** The exam is fully case-based.
- **Weightage:** While the exam is comprehensive (covering all material), the weightage is higher for lectures 8 through 16.

- **Quiz 2:** 5% weight (same as Quiz 1); MCQs based on 4 lecture sessions; provided in a 10-day window (including at least one weekend).
- **Assignment:** Common to all sections; Individual assignment (15 marks); "Experiential learning" format (requires the student to relate real-world problems/situations to the theories studied).
- **Case Study WIPL:** To be discussed in Session 10.

Sources

- Lecture 09 (Group Behavior)
- MPO Session 9-13 2026.pdf
- MBA ZG511 Lecture 9.pptx
- MBAZG511_Managing People and Organization - Lectures 1-9 (2).pdf
- MBAZG511_Managing People and Organization - Lectures 1-9.pdf